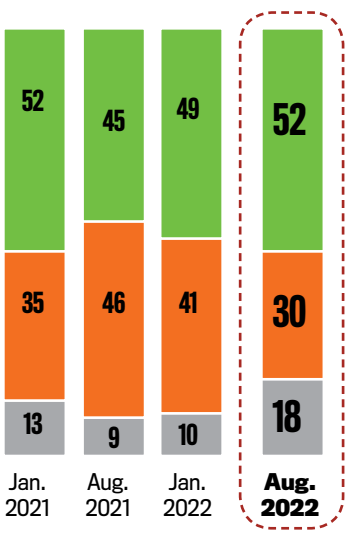


ANI

Q. Do you think the Congress will be better off without the Gandhi family?



(All figures in percentage)

per cent think the longest-serving president of the Congress still has it in her to rebuild the party. There is more bad news for Priyanka Gandhi, still recovering from the abysmal performance the Congress put up under her leadership in the Uttar Pradesh assembly election earlier this year. Often projected by a section of the Congress as the alternative to Rahul, she earned the faith of only seven per cent respondents, against 14 per cent backing 44-year-old Sachin Pilot, who has been patiently waiting for the approval of the Gandhis to replace Ashok Gehlot as the chief minister of Rajasthan.

This diminishing faith in the Congress leadership coupled with West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee's troubles in the aftermath of one of her top ministers landing in jail on charges of corruption, has resulted in a disillusionment among respondents about whether Opposition parties can form an effective alliance against Modi. Only 42 per cent respondents think it is still possible, against 40 per cent who had backed the idea in the previous two MOTN polls.

While fewer respondents now see Rahul Gandhi and Mamata Banerjee as the Opposition's alternative to Modi, Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, now on an expansion drive following his party, AAP, forming the government in Punjab earlier this year, has seen a sudden jump in his ratings. More than 27 per cent respondents across the country find him best suited to lead the Opposition alliance, up from 16 per cent six months ago. What's more interesting is that Kejriwal's ratings see a further jump in the west (31 per cent)—Modi's home turf—and in the northeast (34 per cent)—where the PM's popularity is the highest.

He may, though, find another challenger in the form of Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar who left the NDA on August 9 to join hands with the opposition RJD and Congress. Nitish has demonstrated prime ministerial ambitions in the past and may try to emerge as the rallying point for a united front which has eluded the Opposition parties till now. His personal equation with its leaders, including Mamata Banerjee (TMC), K. Chandrashekar Rao (TRS) and Sharad Pawar (NCP), certainly give him an edge. At the same time, the latter will also be wary of his tendency to do political somersaults at will. There is no doubt, though, that the return of Nitish to the Opposition space will have an impact beyond the 40 Lok Sabha seats from Bihar. ■